

Chapter 58 - Substitution

This song tortured everyone present immensely. The only person who didn't show strange emotions about Feng Yue's singing was Qian He.

Feng Yue barely managed to finish the entire song under Zhiyu's guidance. For as long as she sang, Qian He kept the beat for her.

This kind gesture from Qian He eased Feng Yue's feelings considerably. She put down the microphone and sat back down next to Qian He, somewhat embarrassed.

Qian He turned to look at Feng Yue. The dim lighting in the private room made it hard for them to see each other's expressions clearly, but Feng Yue could still see those bright eyes looking at her.

"Miss Feng, you could have quietly told me that you're not good at singing," Qian He whispered in Feng Yue's ear.

Feng Yue curved her lips, her psychological burden suddenly lightening. She had never been good at vocal music since childhood, but whether when she was young or when she got a bit older, whenever she sang on stage, regardless of how it turned out, there would always be people who, for various reasons, would flatter her with insincere praise.

She rarely encountered someone as straightforward as Qian He.

"Mm, I'm really not good at singing. I've been like this since I was little," Feng Yue looked at Qian He and said calmly.

Perhaps her mother was right - Qian He was a good child, and she shouldn't reject the friendly olive branch others extended.

Feng Yue's singing was just a small interlude. With Zhiyu, the microphone hog, keeping things lively, everyone quickly forgot about it.

However, Wang Huili went out to answer a phone call midway, and after finishing the call, she came to say goodbye to Qian He, saying something had happened at home and she needed to go back first.

Qian He was already somewhat dissatisfied with what she had done today, so seeing her wanting to leave early, she didn't try to keep her and let her go.

Only Feng Yue felt somewhat uneasy watching Wang Huili leave.

Because Feng Yue wasn't good at singing, and Qian He had her little thoughts, the group didn't stay at the KTV for too long before moving to another venue.

After Wang Huili left the private room, she took the elevator down to the underground parking garage on the second basement level, then drove her car out of the parking garage.

The exit of Sen'er Hotel's underground parking garage was in an alley behind the hotel. After exiting, Wang Huili saw a man crouching in the shadows smoking.

Seeing Wang Huili's car, the man immediately threw his cigarette butt on the ground, stamped out the sparks with his foot, and came forward.

"Miss Wang."

Wang Huili rolled down her window and nodded at him. "Follow me."

The two avoided the exit's surveillance cameras and went to a surveillance blind spot. Wang Huili sat in her car, opened her phone, and showed the man a photo. "The target is this person, and this is her car. Find an opportunity to sneak into the parking garage, then proceed according to the plan."

"Yes!" The man responded, then rolled his eyes with a calculating gleam. "About the payment..."

Wang Huili glanced at him coldly, as if looking at him would lower her own status. "You won't be short of payment, but you must do the job well. Even if someone discovers it later, you must know what to say and what not to say."

"Of course, of course. Miss Wang, don't worry. We've cooperated so many times already - you can rest assured," the man smiled obsequiously, then watched Wang Huili's car drive away.

Remembering the disgusted look the young lady had just given him, the man spat toward a nearby sewer. "Damn it, what's a poisonous woman like her acting so arrogant for!"

Then he took out his phone and called his subordinates. "Come over, time to work."

Their group's dinner tonight was Kobe beef¹ that Qian He had pre-ordered from abroad. The ingredients were flown in this morning, and even the chef was specifically requested by Qian He.

Throughout the meal, Qian He took special care of Feng Yue, to the point where even Xu Yan couldn't stand watching.

So when Qian He enthusiastically approached Feng Yue again to say something, Xu Yan couldn't help but grab her by the neck and make her switch seats.

Zhiyu giggled beside Feng Yue, and seeing Feng Yue's confused expression, she explained, "Miss Feng, don't mind her. Hua'er just really likes you, so she's being... well, fanatical."

Feng Yue was stunned. "Likes me?" If she remembered correctly, she and Qian He shouldn't have had any interaction.

Seeing her expression, Zhiyu knew she might have misunderstood, so she added, "It's probably like how fans like their idols. Basically, all of Hua'er's behavior can be summed up in two words - star chasing."

Feng Yue was even more confused. "Star chasing? Me?"

Zhiyu smiled, glancing at Xu Yan and Qian He who were still fighting nearby. "Yes, ever since Hua'er accidentally came across one of your videos, she's liked you."

Feng Yue hadn't expected that as just an ordinary food blogger, she could experience idol treatment.

Over there, Xu Yan and Qian He were still fighting over the seat next to Feng Yue.

"That's enough. If you keep this up, how is Miss Feng going to eat? Sit properly!"

"I promise I'll sit nicely and eat properly. Let me sit back!"

"No way, sit here quietly!"

"I won't, I won't, I just won't."

"Didn't you say you're treating Miss Feng like an idol? Idols can't have private contact with fans - don't harm her."

"You're being unreasonable!" Qian He's face turned red with anger.

In the end, Zhiyu gave up her seat on Feng Yue's other side to Qian He, and the two finally called a temporary truce.

Feng Yue had never encountered someone who viewed her this way before, so she found it somewhat novel.

"Qian He, why do you like me?"

Qian He was angrily poking at the food on her plate with her fork. Hearing Feng Yue ask this, she looked at her with surprise. "What kind of question is that? Of course it's because you're wonderful!"

"But I don't have anything particularly outstanding..." Feng Yue still didn't understand.

Qian He propped her chin up and thought. "Maybe it's fate. You give me the feeling that's very similar to my memory of my mother."

Feng Yue was even more stunned.

"My mom was already an older mother when she was pregnant with me. She passed away a few years after giving birth to me, which means the role of 'mother' in my memory is very blurry. But I remember she loved me very much. My dad has loved me and been good to me since I was little, but eventually he found me a stepmother. I don't blame him - my stepmother is actually quite good to me too. But the feeling they give me is always different from that figure in my memory."

Qian He looked seriously at Feng Yue. "But when I accidentally saw your video once, I suddenly felt that if my mom were still here, she would probably be like you in the video. Gentle like silk."

As she spoke, Qian He became somewhat shy. "Oh no, I don't mean I see you as my mother. I just think you give people a very comfortable feeling. Seeing your videos makes me feel at peace."

This confession really startled Feng Yue, but she felt more pity for Qian He than anything else.

"If there's a chance, you can come to my house for dinner. I'll cook for you?" Feng Yue smiled with crinkled eyes. "After all, you're my first true fan?"

Qian He's eyes lit up as she looked at Feng Yue. "Really? Is that really okay?!"

Feng Yue nodded. "Mm, as long as you don't mind my cooking."

"I won't!" Qian He hugged Feng Yue's left arm and rubbed against it happily.

Feng Yue was caught off guard by this gesture. Just as she was about to say something, she heard her phone ring.

Feng Yue looked at the familiar but unlabeled number, and her expression became calm. "Sorry, I need to take this call."

Feng Yue didn't get up, just sat there and answered the phone.

"Ah Yue, it's me."

"Mm." Feng Yue's voice was cold. "What's the matter?"

Qian He was seeing Feng Yue with this kind of expression for the first time, so she gave her an inquiring look.

"Are you... at home now? I have something I want to give you," Yan Lin said.

"I'm out. If it's not something important, you don't need to give it to me."

Yan Lin was silent for a moment. "It's a New Year's gift I want to give you. Can you... accept it?"

Yan Lin's voice still sounded rather weak, and Feng Yue couldn't help but think again about how the other person had faced life-threatening danger to save her.

So the refusal that had reached her lips was swallowed back down by Feng Yue. After all, she owed Yan Lin her life. "I'm at Sen'er Hotel. You can leave it at the front desk."

After Feng Yue finished speaking, without waiting for Yan Lin to say anything, she hung up directly. Just accepting the gift was the biggest concession she could make.

Qian He glanced at Feng Yue and asked cautiously, "Was that Yan Lin?"

Feng Yue came back to her senses and put away her phone. "Mm."

"Aren't you going to see her?"

"There's no need."

"Then what if she comes again next time?" Qian He looked at Feng Yue. "I don't really understand what happened between you two, but I can see that you don't really want to have any more contact with her. But you can't keep avoiding her like this forever. If you're willing, you could go talk things out with her clearly."

Feng Yue sat quietly, but her mind was thinking about what Qian He had said. Before that accident happened, she had already talked with Yan Lin, and she had indeed managed to have no contact with Yan Lin.

But that accident and Yan Lin's rebirth had made their relationship strange again. She couldn't be so heartless as to completely reject Yan Lin, but she also didn't want to have any more contact with her.

Qian He was right - she couldn't keep avoiding like this. It would only make the other person more aggressive.

She and Yan Lin needed to have a face-to-face talk. One thing at a time - Yan Lin had indeed saved her life, but she didn't want to do anything like repaying with her body.

Feng Yue took out her phone and sent a message to that unlabeled number, setting up a time.

She scheduled the meeting for when their gathering would end, at the coffee shop on the first floor of Sen'er Hotel.

Because Qian He and the others still had to go to the city center square for New Year's countdown, the hotel dinner would pretty much be the end for Feng Yue.

Since Feng Yue had to meet Yan Lin, Qian He suggested she go get Feng Yue's car first, and after she finished talking with Yan Lin, they would drive directly to the city center square.

Feng Yue nodded and handed her keys to Qian He. Going to the parking garage with Qian He was Xu Yan.

The two took the elevator down to the second basement level. Their two cars weren't parked in the same place, so they separated.

Qian He walked around looking for the car with the keys, while Xu Yan had already found her car and was sitting inside waiting for Qian He.

After waiting for quite a while, Xu Yan still hadn't seen any sign of Qian He. She frowned and waited a bit more, then took out her phone to call Qian He.

The phone kept ringing for a long time, but no one answered. Xu Yan's heart jumped with a bad premonition.

She quickly opened the car door and got out, continuously calling Qian He's phone. When she found the parking spot where Feng Yue's car was parked, she only found the car and Qian He's phone and bag dropped on the ground.

The phone kept ringing, sounding so piercing in the empty parking garage.

Xu Yan's face changed, and she quickly called Zhiyu, who was waiting for them upstairs.

"Xiao Yu, Hua'er is missing! Quickly go contact the hotel to check the surveillance, and also go find Feng Yue!"

Footnotes:

¹ Kobe beef (神戸和牛) - A premium grade of beef from the Tajima strain of Japanese Black cattle, raised in Japan's Kobe region and considered one of the world's finest meats.